

OUR ECONOMIC HERITAGE

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I am asked to contribute an article on the economic heritage of the Syrian Christians of Kerala. Twenty-five years ago, I had material for writing a book on the subject. But today, pre-occupied with more immediate problems, I find it difficult to write even a short article, especially as my notes and papers are locked up far away. However, I shall note here a few points, leaving it to younger men to attempt something more elaborate and scholarly.

Kerala's Trading Class

A remarkable feature of Kerala sociology in the past was the communal division of labour that prevailed for long. Under the social dharma long favoured, each community specialised in some basic profession. The Nambudiri Brahmin studied religion and philosophy and pursued literature as a full-time avocation. The Nair was the soldier and was responsible for the defence of the country and for internal law and order. If there was any industry, it was chiefly the function of the Eazhava (or Tiya). The Pulaya, Pariah and other labouring classes pursued the humdrum art of cultivation, although they did not own the land they tilled. One important profession, that of the Vaisya (trade and business), remained without votaries, and the Syrian Christians (Nazrani Mapilas) filled in this void for many centuries, at least in the southern part of Kerala (Cochin State and Travancore north of Quilon). In fact at one time, the term Vyapari (trader) was a synonym of the word Nazrani (see e. g. "Keralolpathi" which was written not later than 1700). It is also significant that in some areas, the title 'Chetti' was widely used by Christians. It is no wonder

that the Headman of the Syrian Community in Cranganore who received a copper plate grant from a Cheraman Perumal was called in the grant *oajotaoos Gejodboajrajoajgji* (The royal merchant of the Cheraman world).

Foreign Origin ?

How did Syrian Christians come to occupy such a prominent place in trade ? The indigenous Christian folk, it is true, occupied a high social position, but like the Nambudiris and Nairs, from whom they were drawn, they shunned trade. The change must have come by the influx of Syrian colonists from Baghdad and Basra in early days. One colony in 345 A. D. settled in Cranganore; another in 825 A. D. settled in Quilon. These colonists hailed from lands where the ancient Chaldean civilization flourished. In the 4th century, Edessa was a great seat of learning. In the 9th century, Baghdad was at the height of its power under the Caliphs who were great patrons of learning and arts. This perhaps explains the proficiency of these colonists in trade, medicine (and perhaps in astrology too) and preference for town life. This also explains the high position secured by these colonists in Kerala and the privileges which they obtained from its Ruling families. The new-comers eventually got mixed up with the indigenous Christian community - the descendants of St. Thomas's converts. At any rate in the areas around the two towns above mentioned, such mingling did take place. In other areas trade was slow to develop; people stuck to land and carried on agriculture, living in their scattered homesteads like the Nambudiris and Nairs.

But the source of this heritage may not all be foreign. There is a tradition that large numbers of Tamil Christians settled down in Kerala owing to persecution in Tamil land, and that many of them were (Vellala) Chettis. There is reason to think that such colonists did come from Mylapore and Negapatnam. It is even more certain that Christian Chettis from Coimbatore, mostly "Vantias, migrated to Kerala at some later date. Perhaps these are the classes that called themselves Chettis. Some of these still remain separate from the main body of Nazranis.

There were also powerful trading organisations formerly in Kerala, like Manigramam and Anjuvarnam which were high in royal favour. The origin of these is obscure; but judging from various early documents, it is likely that these were connected with Christian and Jewish colonists who settled down for trade on the Malabar Coast.

Whatever be the origin of the commercial tradition among Kerala Christians, it is certain that it struck fast root among them. They set up new trading centres in Cranganore (Mahadevar Pattinam) and Quilon (Kurakonil) and this gave a great fillip to economic activity in Kerala. They then

migrated to the interior and set up new trading centre?. Unlike other Malayalis, they preferred to live in towns. This peculiarity in rural sociology is notable in Cochin and North Travancore. In fact most of the towns in the part of Kerala grew around the bazaars founded by Syrians. Whenever a Ruler sought to enlarge his capital city or founded a new town, he invited Christians to colonize the place and he built for them Churches and gave them house sites, often taxfree. In many such towns, the Christian church is found located in the immediate vicinity of the temple indicating thereby that the bans connected with this are comparatively modern.

They were not merely shop-keepers; wholesale trade was also largely in their hands. While they bought up local produce for sale outside, they also brought outside goods into Kerala for consumption here. This necessitated their maintaining extensive contacts with the neighbouring districts Tinnevely, Madura and Coimbatore, and numerous caravans of bullocks and buffaloes plied on their behalf on the various ghat routes from Kerala to the Tamil country. Such tracks are even now in use.

The Pepper Trade

The export trade of Malabar was largely in the hands of foreigners, but local wholesalers too functioned in it in some ways. Pepper was the great export staple of Kerala from early days; it was also an important article of world trade, till early 19th century, because it was then essential for the preservation of meat and was a valued spice all over the world. For long the whole world depended on Kerala for this article. It thus became possible for pepper to shape the destinies of nations for long.

The greed for pepper caused a serious drain of treasure from Rome and according to Pliny, this brought about the decline of the mighty Roman Empire. But this trade continued in the Middle Ages and was controlled by Venitians among others. The Syrian Christians functioned prominently in this trade and this perhaps led to their colonisation in Kerala as shown above. After the expansion of Muslim-Arab influence (10th century A.D.), Syrian trade was largely confined to Southern Kerala. The European traveller, John Marignoli, who visited Quilon in 1320 A. D., records that the whole world's pepper came from Quilon and that "Christians of St. Thomas" were the proprietors of that pepper. Although they were not perhaps the sole proprietors, they must have been the chief wholesalers from whom foreign traders bought it. They also maintained the royal customs house at Quilon and elsewhere, and collected duty for the King. This also enhanced their influence.

The coming of the Portuguese curtailed Syrian trade but the market in pepper greatly expanded in Europe. The Dutch followed the Portuguese. It was the Dutch attempt at pepper monopoly in the 17th century and the consequent high prices that led to the foundation of the East India Company. The Dutch were indeed ousted from Malabar, but with that also declined Malabar's pepper monopoly. The cultivation of pepper in Sumatra and other

parts of Dutch East Indies began only in the 17th century with seedlings exported in large quantities from Kerala by the Dutch Government. The Zamorin of Calicut then consoled his countrymen with the flippancy remark that although the seedling could be exported, the monsoon weather conditions of (മലയാളത്തിലെ കാലാവസ്ഥ) cannot be. But this proved rather futile. For, Dutch Indies subsequently became much the largest producer and exporter of pepper, and Kerala's share fell to hardly 1 per-cent of the total world supply.

Cocconut and Timber

With improvements in cattle-breeding in Europe and changes in diet habits, the world demand for pepper declined rapidly in the 16th century, and this greatly affected Kerala. But in the meantime, cocconut had come to the fore, owing to the growing demand for copra and oil. This trade also was largely controlled by Syrians. Oil pressing was first a cottage industry among them), and subsequently oil mills came to be set up. The coir industry flourished since Portuguese times, and Syrians have had a large share in it.

In the 18th century, when great demand arose for Malabar teak wood, Christian traders found a great opportunity. The East India Company needed teak in large quantities for building ships (one of the ships built with such teak was "Victory" used by Nelson when he defeated Napoleon at Trafalgar), and large contracts for this were taken by the well-known Nazrani merchant, Mathoo Tarakan, and judging from the fact that the arrears owed to him by the Company after his death amounted Rs. 50 lakhs or more, his business must have been a large one indeed. Tarakan also flourished by the salt monopoly in Travancore, and this eventually brought him to grief. Shrewd as he was, Tarakan did not realize the political significance attaching to salt tax. He indeed lived long before Mahatma Gandhi's Dandi march !

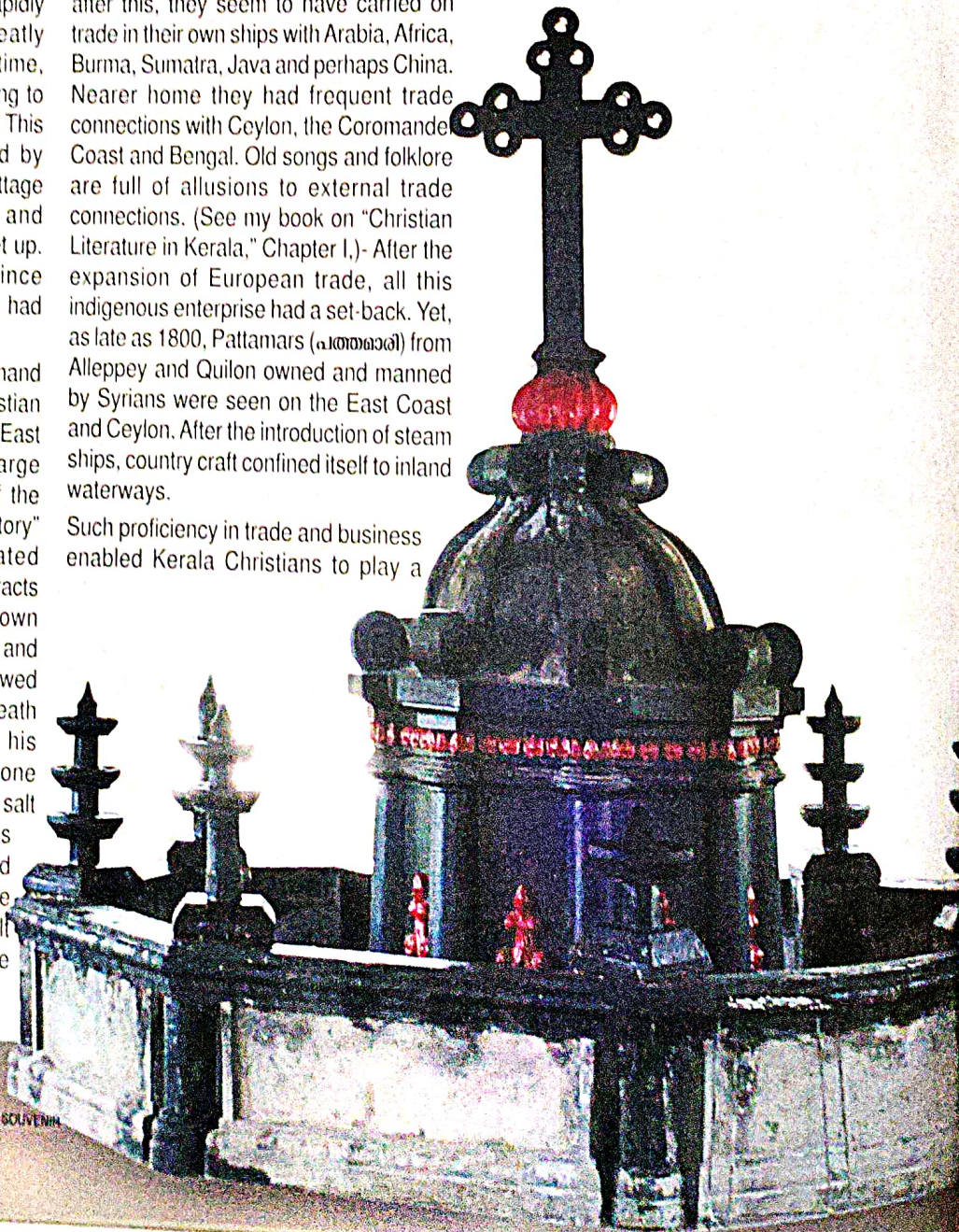
In the north, the Nazranis have long played a prominent part in the trade in oil and aracanuts. Palghat was formerly (and perhaps also now) a great centre of trade in these commodities, and it is worth noting that the Nazranis had a special warehouse (നാസ്രാണി) at Palghat where they stored their produce. This was a co-operative concern and reminds one of the ware-houses maintained by Hansa merchants in Mediaeval Europe in far-off trading centres.

Commerce and Shipping

The Syrian colonists had their own ships and were adepts in navigation. After Arab expansion, there was some decline. Even after this, they seem to have carried on trade in their own ships with Arabia, Africa, Burma, Sumatra, Java and perhaps China. Nearer home they had frequent trade connections with Ceylon, the Coromandel Coast and Bengal. Old songs and folklore are full of allusions to external trade connections. (See my book on "Christian Literature in Kerala," Chapter I.)- After the expansion of European trade, all this indigenous enterprise had a set-back. Yet, as late as 1800, Pattamars (പട്ടമര) from Alleppey and Quilon owned and manned by Syrians were seen on the East Coast and Ceylon. After the introduction of steam ships, country craft confined itself to inland waterways.

Such proficiency in trade and business enabled Kerala Christians to play a

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prominent part in the service of the Ruling Princes of the land—as financiers and tax collectors, even as ministers and ambassadors. Such preferments came to them not only in Kerala, but perhaps from outside also. Tradition has it that a Syrian Christian was revenue minister in the Vijayanagar Empire in its heyday. It may therefore not be considered a matter for surprise that a Syrian Christian became the first Indian Finance Minister of the Central Government of India.

The Tradition goes on

The prominence of Syrians in internal trade has continued to our own day, and in spite of adverse forces the tradition has been maintained. Cranganore declined and Quilon lost its favoured place, but numerous new towns have come to flourish, and most of them — especially Trichur and Kunnampalam in the north and Alleppey, Kottayam and Changanacherry among others in the south — owe a great deal to Christian business enterprise.

From trade, banking is not a far cry. Trade needs banking, and traders can easily become bankers. Kuri is the indigenous form of banking in Malabar (was its origin Chinese?), and kuries have been mostly conducted by Christians. Then came the joint stock bank with its collection of deposits from far and wide. Here too the Christians took the lead and the great majority of Banks in Travancore and Cochin owe much to their lead and managing capacity. The Dharmodayam Co. which combine in itself kuri, Bank and philanthropy is the high-water mark of achievement in this line.

Banking necessarily leads on to industry. Something has been done in this line also, but much still remains to be done. Let it be noted that the trading and banking classes in the north and even the Nattu-kottai Chettiers of the South have lately taken to industry as their main avocation. There is no reason why the

Kerala trading class should lag behind.

Agricultural Advance

As mentioned above, the indigenous community of Christians who mostly lived in the interior continued to keep out of trade, and agriculture was their favourite occupation. Nor were they confined to traditional methods of agriculture. They made important improvements in the cultivation of cocoanut, pepper and ginger. Pepper, which formerly came from forests where wild vines nestled on shady trees, became a garden crop under the ministrations of Christian tillers. New vine strains were evolved by them. The planting of cocoanut topes on the Western coast-strip was also largely due to Christian enterprise. Thus the jungly river valleys of Meenachil and Pampa became smiling pepper gardens, and the malarial swamps of Kuttanad, formerly infested by alligators and crocodiles, became productive paddy fields and shady cocoanut topes providing nourishment to man in diverse forms.

Heredity is a potent factor in human affairs. It is interesting to find that while trade and business and banking have flourished in areas which came under the influence of the Syrian colonists, the recent advances in agriculture, especially planting, have come out chiefly under the leadership of the indigenous Christian folk who always looked to land as their mainstay. They who improved the wild areas of Meenachil and Pampa river valleys are also responsible for the large expansion of cultivation in hilly tracts like Thodupuzha and Peermade. Not satisfied with the limited scope for such expansion at home, some of them have lately transported their enterprise to the fertile areas in North Malabar. It is to be hoped that they will go further, and one may not be surprised if before long a daring band of young men will go thousands of miles away to the promising land of Brazil (in S. America) where crops familiar to them — ginger, pepper, rubber, tapioca — can be grown at much less cost and much higher profit, and where in addition a

welcome home and easy capital are available to honest folk who wish to prosper by hard work.

Conclusion

In India many communities have shown remarkable capacity for trade. The Gujaratis and Marwaris stand pre-eminent in this respect. The Parsis who number hardly one lakh have been the pioneers of Indian industry and have shown commendable aptitude for business leadership. The Syrian Christians of Kerala stand far below these communities in achievement, but they can at least claim that their economic life is more broad-based, that they not only trade and speculate in goods but produce them, that the plough is as much their concern as the loom and the shop-counter. Past achievement may not be great, but the tradition established may stand our people in good stead, and may give them some confidence to pursue such careers as trade and business management, and even to occupy high positions of leadership as Finance or Commerce Ministers of Government.

Great industrial opportunities are before Kerala, and it remains to be seen what use Syrian Christians are going to make of them. Recent advances in centres like Trichur raise hopes in this matter; the Dharmodayam Co. in particular, has shown that the objects in view is not selfish money-making nor mere communal aggrandisement, but the common good of the country. Success is sure, if trade and industry are steadily pursued in such commendable spirit.